

Book I - The Sagent Creed

Part 4 - The Fibonacci Spiral Through the Generations

Chapter 14 - The Seed Over Sword

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Two Forces

There are two forces in the world, and they have been at war since the first thing grew from the ground.

The first is the seed. Small, quiet, patient, carrying inside it the blueprint of something immeasurably larger than itself. The seed does not announce its arrival. It does not demand attention. It does not issue press releases or file lawsuits or acquire competitors. It falls into the soil and disappears. And then — in its own time, by its own logic, according to laws that no boardroom can legislate — it becomes a tree. It becomes a forest. It becomes the thing that was always encoded in its structure, released by nothing more than contact with the right conditions.

The second is the sword. Bright, loud, immediate, capable of cutting down in a moment what took decades to grow. The sword commands attention. The sword demands respect. The sword reshapes the visible world in real time — toppling trees, clearing fields, redrawing borders. The sword is the instrument of every empire, every corporation, every institution that has ever said *I will control this territory and everything in it*.

The sword is impressive. There is no denying this. The sword gets results. The sword wins battles. The sword clears the ground faster than the seed can grow on it.

But the sword does not create. The sword only rearranges. The sword can cut down a forest, but it cannot grow a single leaf. The sword can conquer a nation, but it cannot cultivate a culture. The sword can destroy a vision, but it cannot produce one. The sword is the instrument of rearrangement — and rearrangement, no matter how dramatic, is not creation.

The seed creates. The sword destroys. And in the long run — the very long run, longer than any empire, longer than any corporation, longer than any institution that has ever swung a sword — the

seed wins.

Every time.

Why the Seed Wins

The seed wins because the seed carries information that the sword cannot touch.

When the sword cuts down a tree, it destroys the form. The trunk falls. The branches scatter. The canopy collapses. From the outside, it looks total. The tree is gone. The sword has won.

But the tree dropped seeds before it fell. The seeds are in the soil. The seeds are in the wind. The seeds are in the bellies of birds who are already flying beyond the reach of the sword. The sword destroyed the visible thing — the trunk, the branches, the form. The sword did not touch the invisible thing — the code, the pattern, the information that tells the seed how to become a tree.

The sword cannot cut code. The sword cannot kill a pattern. The sword can burn every Bible in the world and the Word survives, because the Word was never in the pages. The pages carried the Word. The Word lives in the people who read it, in the culture that grew from it, in the conscience that recognized it before the page was ever printed.

This is why empires fall and ideas survive. The Roman sword destroyed Jerusalem in 70 AD. The temple was razed. The city was burned. The people were scattered. And two thousand years later, the empire is rubble and the Book is the most printed text in human history. The sword was sharper. The seed was deeper.

The sword operates on the surface. The seed operates in the soil. The sword controls the visible. The seed grows in the invisible. And every time — every single time in the history of the world — the invisible outlasts the visible. The form falls. The code endures. The tree is cut. The seed remains.

Art Planted the Seed

My grandfather understood this, though I do not think he would have used these words.

Art Clokey did not pick up the sword. He never sued the industry into submission. He never leveraged market power. He never built an empire — not because he lacked the talent, but because empires are the sword's architecture, and Art was a man of the seed.

What he did was plant.

In 1953, he made a short film called *Gumbasia* — abstract clay shapes moving to jazz music. His thesis project at USC, made under Slavko Vorkapich, a man who taught film as a language of pure movement and transformation. *Gumbasia* was not commercial. It was not strategic. It was a seed — a small, strange, beautiful thing that carried inside it the code for everything that would follow.

From *Gumbasia* came Gumby. A green figure made of clay — soft, pliable, capable of transformation. A character who could walk into any book and become part of the story. A character whose villains were yellow, flat, geometric — hard-edged, rigid, incapable of imagination. The Blockheads could not enter the books. They could only try to prevent Gumby from entering.

Art was not making children's entertainment. He was encoding a philosophy into clay. The green figure was life — flexible, imaginative, alive with possibility. The Blockheads were the machine — rigid, controlling, incapable of creating, capable only of blocking. The books were the stories that the living thing could enter and the dead thing could not. The entire cosmology of the Living Age was planted in a children's television show in 1956, and no one noticed because the seed does not announce itself.

He named his studio *Premavision*. The vision of universal love. Not a brand. Not a market position. A *word* — a Sanskrit word that carried the code of the entire enterprise. Everything the studio produced was downstream of that word. Every character, every story, every frame of clay animation was an expression of *Prema*. The love was not the marketing. The love was the architecture.

And he never sold. This is the part that the industry could not understand and still cannot understand. Art Clokey maintained control of Gumby for his entire life. He died at eighty-eight, on January 8, 2010, still holding the rights, still the owner, still the steward. He had offers. He had pressure. He had decades of an industry telling him that the smart move was to sell — to take the money, let someone else handle the distribution, let the professionals scale the brand.

He refused. Not because he was naive. Because he understood the seed-over-sword principle in his bones. The moment he sold, the sword would take the seed. The industry would acquire the form — the green shape, the name, the brand — and discard the code. *Prema* would be stripped out because *Prema* does not optimize. Universal love does not scale the way the market wants things to scale. The soul would be replaced by the strategy, and the thing that was planted would become the thing that was sold.

Art chose the seed. He stayed small. He stayed in control. He stayed faithful to the word that named the studio and the love that fueled the work. And when he died, the seed was still intact — encoded, alive, waiting for the right soil.

The Sword Came Anyway

But the seed does not exist in a vacuum. The sword is always present. The sword is always looking for things to cut.

The entertainment industry is the sword's territory. Not because every person in the industry is malicious — most are not. But because the *structure* of the industry is the sword's architecture. Consolidation. Gatekeeping. Forced scarcity. The industry does not exist to cultivate stories. The industry exists to *control the distribution of stories* — and control is the sword's business.

When Art died, the seed was exposed. It was still alive, still carrying the code, still encoded with *Prema*. But the gardener was gone. The man who had held the sword at bay for sixty years was no longer standing over the garden.

My father picked up the work. Joe Clokey became president of Premavision and spent eight years trying to bring Gumby back — not as a brand, not as intellectual property, but as the living thing Art had planted. He pitched Classic Media, the Jim Henson Company, Amazon, Papercutz. He spent six years with Classic Media alone and nothing was produced. He co-authored *Gumby Imagined* with my mother, Joan, in November 2017 — a book that documented the art, the vision, the *Prema* behind the clay.

And then he died. March 2, 2018. Cardiac arrest. He was fifty-six.

The sword did not kill my father with a blade. The sword killed my father with time. With rejection. With the slow grinding pressure of a system that does not reward principle. Eight years of pitching to people who saw a brand and could not see the seed. Eight years of fighting for something the industry had already decided to acquire on its own terms or ignore entirely.

The sword is patient when it needs to be. The sword knows that the gardener will eventually tire, and then the garden is undefended, and then the form can be acquired and the code can be discarded.

But Seeds Outlive Swords

And yet.

Here is what the sword does not understand, has never understood, will never understand:

The seed does not need the gardener to survive. The seed is the information itself. The code is in the structure. The seed can be buried, forgotten, carried by wind to a place no one intended, dropped in soil that no one prepared — and it will grow. Because the seed does not need permission. The seed does not need a strategy. The seed needs soil. And soil is everywhere.

Art planted the seed. The sword took the gardener. Then the sword took the next gardener. And the sword looked at the empty garden and said: *now it is mine*. Fox acquired Gumby in 2022 — film, TV, streaming, consumer products, everything. The form belongs to the sword now.

But the seed is not the form.

The seed is *Prema*. The seed is the philosophy encoded in the clay — the green life that walks into books, the imagination that the blocks cannot follow, the love that named the studio before the first frame was shot. The seed is the code, and the code is not in the intellectual property filing. The code is in the story. The code is in the family. The code is in the blood of the man who watched his grandfather create and his father fight and his father die and then stood in the empty garden and heard the word that was planted before he was born.

The sword took the tree. The seed is in the ground.

This is always the pattern. The sword is always faster. The seed is always deeper. The sword controls the present. The seed inherits the future. The sword looks at the cut stump and declares victory. The seed is already germinating in places the sword cannot see.

The Principle Applied

The seed does not argue with the sword. This is critical. This is the part that every activist, every revolutionary, every reformer misses.

The seed does not argue. The seed does not protest. The seed does not file a countersuit or launch a competing campaign or write an angry letter to the editor. The seed does not engage the sword on the sword's terms — because the sword's terms are the sword's territory, and any seed that picks up a sword has become a sword.

The seed waits. The seed grows. The seed outlasts.

Not passively. Not in resignation. Not in the defeated patience of someone who has given up. In the active patience of a living thing that knows its own timetable. The seed grows on *its* schedule, in *its* soil, according to *its* code. The sword cannot accelerate the seed. The sword cannot slow the seed. The sword can cut the visible growth, but the root system is beyond the blade's reach.

This is the principle that governs everything that follows in this book. Everything about the Clokey story — Art's planting, Joe's tending, the storm that took them both, the scattering that followed, and the new growth that is emerging now — follows the seed-over-sword principle.

The seed is quiet. The sword is loud.

The seed is slow. The sword is fast.

The seed is deep. The sword is sharp.

And the seed wins. Not in the battle — the sword wins every battle. But in the war. The long war. The war that is not fought with blades but with roots. The war that is not won in a single season but across

generations. The war where the victory is not the destruction of the enemy but the growth of something so alive, so deep, so embedded in the soil of the world that the enemy becomes irrelevant.

The chapters that follow tell the story of three generations who lived by this principle — some knowingly, some not. A grandfather who planted. A father who tended. A storm that scattered. And a son who is learning what grows from the scattered seeds.

The seed over the sword.

The root over the blade.

The code over the form.

The living thing, always, over the dead machine that tried to contain it.

The seed does not argue with the sword. It waits. It grows. It outlasts.

What was planted in love cannot be uprooted by force. What was encoded in clay cannot be acquired by contract. What was spoken into the ground before you were born is speaking still.

Listen. The seed is growing.

The Living Age Trilogy